

Union Membership and White Racial Politics

Presented by Zahra Khan



Original Study

Abstract

"In this article, we investigate the role of union membership in shaping white racial attitudes. We draw upon research in history and American political development to generate a theory of interracial labor politics, in which union membership reduces racial resentment. Cross-sectional analyses consistently show that white union members have lower racial resentment and greater support for policies that benefit African Americans. More importantly, our panel analysis suggests that gaining union membership between 2010 and 2016 reduced racial resentment among white workers."

Frymer, Paul, and Jacob M. Grumbach. 2020. "Labor Unions and

White Racial Politics." *American Journal of Political*

Science 65 (1): 225–40. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12537>.

Details of the Study

The authors develop a theory of labor unions and racial attitudes that predicts union membership reduces racial resentment towards African Americans rooted, in historical realities. Throughout this study, the authors identified a gap in the literature that has focused on white racial politics, which has often ignored the lens of labor. They also make a note to say that their theory is temporally and contextually bound.

The study uses data from CCES and VSG between 2010–2016, which the authors use both for cross-sectional and panel models, which ask (1) “The Irish, Italians, Jews, and many other minorities overcame prejudice and worked their way up. Blacks should do the same without any special favors.” (2) “Generations of slavery and discrimination have created conditions that make it difficult for Blacks to work their way out of the lower class” (reverse coded). (3) It’s really a matter of some people not trying hard enough; if blacks would only try harder, they could be just as well off as whites. (4) “Over the past few years, blacks have gotten less than they deserve” (reverse coded).

The authors run an OLS linear regression to examine the relationship between Racial Resentment and Union Membership. The authors conduct analyses on both cross-sectional and panel data, while controlling for Age, Gender, Income, Education, and in the panel models, PartyID. IV: Union Membership DV: Racial Resentment

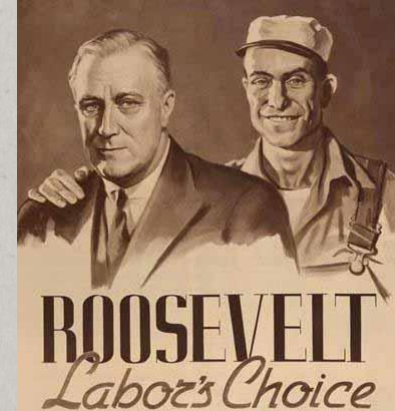
Why Age? Why Age and Why Unions?

Foundations in Historical Research

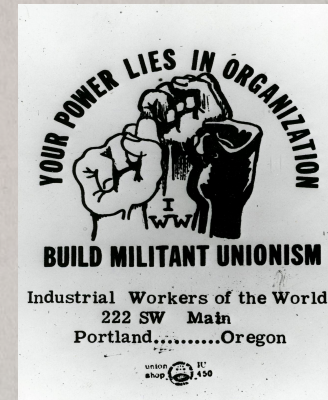
- I chose to add an interaction term between age and union membership. Choosing this interaction term was rooted in historical realities. White union members have a complicated history with xenophobia across the 20th century. This encompasses white union members' role in passing legislation such as the 1924 Johnson-Reed Act and the 1986 Immigration Reform and Control Act directed towards Central American and Mexican Immigrants. Labor unions have also, since the 1930s, been aligned with the Democratic Party and have, especially in times of need, aligned with marginalized groups. Therefore, I wanted to understand whether there is an interaction between age and union membership.



The Wasp - 1883



<https://fdranewdealerinhope.weebly.com/the-new-deal-coalition.html>



https://www.oregonencyclopedia.org/articles/industrial_workers_of_the_world_iww/

CROSS-SECTIONAL - Original

Table 1: Union Membership and Racial Resentment among Whites

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	Racial Resentment		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Union Member	-0.063*** (0.005)	-0.047*** (0.005)	-0.048*** (0.005)
Past Union Member	-0.020*** (0.003)	-0.024*** (0.003)	-0.025*** (0.003)
Female		-0.046*** (0.002)	-0.046*** (0.002)
Income		0.003*** (0.0004)	0.002*** (0.0004)
Age		0.0005*** (0.0001)	0.0005*** (0.0001)
Education		-0.049*** (0.001)	-0.050*** (0.001)
Constant	0.688*** (0.001)	0.946*** (0.012)	0.959*** (0.012)
State Fixed Effects	No	Yes	Yes
Year Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes
Observations	71,431	61,463	61,463
R ²	0.003	0.080	0.081
Adjusted R ²	0.003	0.079	0.080
Residual Std. Error	0.300 (df = 71428)	0.288 (df = 61406)	0.288 (df = 61405)
F Statistic	110.963*** (df = 2; 71428)	95.252*** (df = 56; 61406)	95.157*** (df = 57; 61405)

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

- This is the original model in the study, which yields statistically significant results in which union membership decreased racial resentment. To proceed, I factored age and ran an interaction between the variable and union membership.

CROSS-SECTIONAL - My Twist

Table 6:

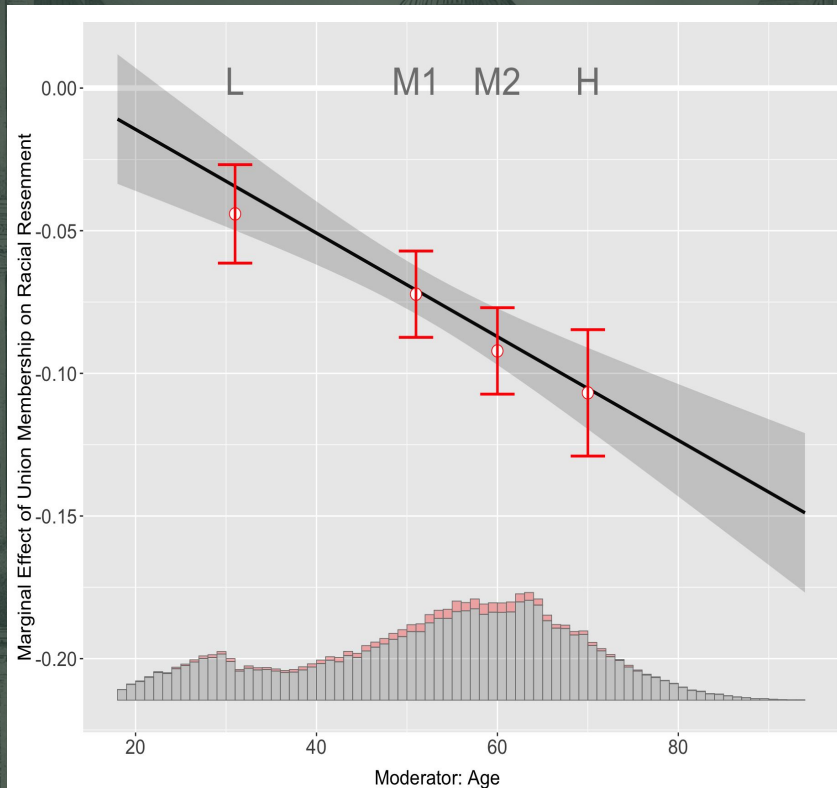
	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	racial resentment		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
union member	-0.063*** (0.005)	-0.013 (0.018)	-0.014 (0.018)
past union member	-0.020*** (0.003)	-0.025*** (0.003)	-0.025*** (0.003)
Female		-0.046*** (0.002)	-0.045*** (0.002)
Income		0.002*** (0.0004)	0.002*** (0.0004)
age 31-50		0.059*** (0.005)	0.057*** (0.005)
age 51-70		0.052*** (0.004)	0.051*** (0.004)
age_binned 70+		0.042*** (0.005)	0.042*** (0.005)
Education		-0.049*** (0.001)	-0.049*** (0.001)
union member: age 31-50		-0.004 (0.020)	-0.003 (0.020)
union member: age 51-70		-0.051*** (0.019)	-0.050*** (0.019)
union member:age 70+		-0.083*** (0.026)	-0.082*** (0.026)
Constant	0.688*** (0.001)	0.926*** (0.012)	0.940*** (0.012)
State Fixed Effects	No	Yes	Yes
Year Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes
Observations	71,431	61,463	61,463
R ²	0.003	0.083	0.084
Adjusted R ²	0.003	0.082	0.083
Residual Std. Error	0.300 (df = 71428)	0.288 (df = 61401)	0.287 (df = 61400)
F Statistic	110.963*** (df = 2; 71428)	90.771*** (df = 61; 61401)	90.471*** (df = 62; 61400)

```

1
2 data <- data %>%
3   mutate(age_binned = cut(age,
4                             breaks = c(18, 30, 50, 70, Inf),
5                             labels = c("18-30", "31-50", "51-70", "70+"),
6                             include.lowest = TRUE))
7
8 lm_bv <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_member + past_union_member, data[data$
9   race==1,])
10 lm_controls1 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_member + past_union_member +
11   factor(gender) + famincome + age_binned + educ + factor(state_pre) + age_
12   binned*union_member, data[data$race==1,])

```

- For younger members, union membership has no significant effect on racial resentment. However, for members ages 51-70, the term indicates that union membership almost completely cancels out the effect of age on racial resentment. Further, for those over the age of seventy, union membership pushes them below the baseline.



Marginal Effects:

This graph communicates the main findings in the previous model:

- The marginal effect decreases as age increases.
- The histogram at the bottom indicates the distribution of the of the respondents ages showing that most the respondents were between the ages of 50 and about 70.

PANEL MODEL - Original

Table 5: CCES Panel Results of Union Membership and Racial Resentment among Whites

	Outcome: Racial Resentment			
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4
Gained Union Membership	-0.055*** (0.018)	-0.055*** (0.018)	-0.051*** (0.019)	-0.049*** (0.018)
Lost Union Membership	0.0002 (0.032)	-0.00001 (0.032)	-0.003 (0.033)	0.009 (0.033)
Racial Resentment (t-1)	0.899*** (0.005)	0.899*** (0.005)	0.884*** (0.005)	0.797*** (0.007)
Party ID (Democratic)				-0.124*** (0.005)
Income			0.0004 (0.001)	-0.0005 (0.001)
Female			-0.007* (0.003)	0.002 (0.003)
Age			0.0003** (0.0001)	0.0002 (0.0001)
Education			-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)
Constant	0.056*** (0.004)	0.054*** (0.004)	0.084*** (0.012)	0.215*** (0.014)
Year Fixed Effects	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	10908	10908	9726	9617
R-squared	0.749	0.749	0.749	0.764
Adj. R-squared	0.749	0.749	0.749	0.764
Residual Std. Error	0.165 (df = 10904)	0.165 (df = 10903)	0.165 (df = 9717)	0.161 (df = 9607)
F Statistic	10863.440*** (df = 3; 10904)	8148.794*** (df = 4; 10903)	3629.656*** (df = 8; 9717)	3454.658*** (df = 9; 9607)

***p < .01; **p < .05; *p < .1

```

1 lm_1 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_
lag, data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
2 lm_2 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_
lag + factor(year), data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
3 lm_3 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_
lag + faminc_10 + factor(gender_10) + age_10 + educ_10 + factor(year),
data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
4 lm_4 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_
lag + dem_id_2010 + faminc_10 + factor(gender_10) + age_10 + educ_10 +
factor(year), data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])

```

- This is the original model in the study, which yields statistically significant results for union membership and racial resentment. Once again I factored and binned the age variable prior to running the interaction term.

PANEL MODEL – MY TWIST

	racial_resentment			
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4
union_gained	-0.055*** (0.018)	-0.055*** (0.018)	-0.048* (0.028)	-0.041 (0.028)
union_lost	0.0002 (0.032)	-0.00001 (0.032)	-0.004 (0.033)	0.008 (0.033)
racial_resentment_lag	0.899*** (0.005)	0.899*** (0.005)	0.884*** (0.006)	0.795*** (0.007)
dem_id_2010				-0.125*** (0.006)
famine_10			0.0004 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)
factor(gender_10)1			-0.007** (0.004)	0.002 (0.003)
age_factor[60,80]			-0.005 (0.004)	-0.004 (0.004)
age_factor[80,100]			0.004 (0.007)	-0.005 (0.007)
educ_10			-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)
union_gained:age_factor[60,80]			-0.007 (0.040)	-0.007 (0.039)
union_gained:age_factor[80,100]			-0.003 (0.167)	-0.006 (0.162)
Constant	0.056*** (0.004)	0.054*** (0.004)	0.108*** (0.009)	0.234*** (0.010)
Year Fixed Effects	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	10908	10908	9333	9228
R-squared	0.749	0.749	0.750	0.765
Adj. R-squared	0.749	0.749	0.749	0.765
Residual Std. Error	0.165 (df = 10904)	0.165 (df = 10903)	0.164 (df = 9321)	0.160 (df = 9215)
F Statistic	10863.440*** (df = 3; 10904)	8148.794*** (df = 4; 10903)	2539.181*** (df = 11; 9321)	2497.975*** (df = 12; 9215)

***p < .01; **p < .05; *p < .1

```
1 lm_1 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_lag, data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
2 lm_2 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_lag + factor(year), data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
3 lm_3 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_lag + famine_10 + factor(gender_10) + age_factor + educ_10 + factor(year) + union_gained*age_factor, data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
4 lm_4 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_lag + dem_id_2010 + famine_10 + factor(gender_10) + age_factor + educ_10 + factor(year) + union_gained*age_factor, data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
```

- After running the model, I found that the relationship between union membership and racial resentment does not change over time differently for younger vs older respondents. A possible reason for the lack of significance could be that, as respondents age, their opinions do not change meaningfully; the within-person variation attributable to aging over time is either very small or null in 2010 and 2014.